



An interview with the
publishers of Hanuman
Boy Warrior

India's first PS2 Game

Kumar Jhuremalani and Siddharth Parwatay

Under what category does this game fall in - RPG or Platform?

With respect to the character and what is happening in the gameplay, I'll put it as a platformer and the action genre. Since Hanuman has to go through a series of challenges and fight demons, it falls under the action genre. However, the movement around the smaller challenges such as swinging in the tree and collecting fruits puts it in the platformer genre.

Is this game meant only for India or worldwide?

It's not a worldwide launch for two reasons. In terms of the target audience, it's targeted at Indians and the Indian diaspora globally. Therefore, it'll most probably be launched in the UK, Middle East and most probably South Africa. However, being the first game with an Indian developer, our primary objective since the very beginning was to make it big in the Indian markets. The idea was intended to appeal to the Indian audience anywhere, not use Indian mythology to create a world game.

How long did it take from scratch?

The whole journey started when we had the developers' conference last year (DevStation Mumbai '08), which was also a first in its category (it was the first dev conference out of London). That was April 2008; the final game after alpha, beta, and QC (quality control) came in our hands mid-January. Effectively, it was a 10-month cycle.

With a price tag of Rs. 499, are you trying to undercut piracy?

Earlier, pirated games were priced around Rs. 125 a game, while our products were priced at Rs. 1,500. We have now brought this down to Rs. 499 with Hanuman. While creating games for the Indian market, one of the main parameters was to create games around the Rs. 499 price point without any sub-optimisation in the animation quality, programming, or the gameplay complexities. However, the level or the depth of the game is perhaps 8 hours of gameplay, not more than that.

How was it working with Indian developers?

Being very close to the dev team from UK, something coming out with a ten month cycle is nothing short of a miracle. And Aurna is not the only one. In June, you will have two quiz games from Candella. In another two months, two more games in PSP and PS2 SKU, from a company called GameShastra. One is a world quiz - it helps you in passing civil services and Joint Entrance type examinations. Earlier, we thought all that's done here is Flash games, but it turns out there is more to it. Gaming is being covered in a big way. Gaming critics are being well heard. Gaming distribution is becoming big, modern channels are putting in gaming retailing sections, and experience zones will also start following. Arcade games are also coming up. The place where it falls short is that the gaming industry is not recognised as a full-fledged industry. The government is not in a position to understand the full value of this industry. The fact that it can jump from zero to a five billion dollar industry even if it takes five years - that is not understood.

How practical is gaming as a career in India?

If you want to make gaming a career in India, you have to have an interest in gaming, because it is a very creative field. This can be in the story telling part, the programming part, or the animation part. In terms of programming skills, you need to



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have this. I have sat with programmers and am amazed with their artistic tendencies, their programming skills and optimisation techniques. I feel console gaming or PC gaming is all about optimisation. Only then will you be able to make a fantastic game. Career wise, although there aren't sufficient institutes out there (and even if there are), institutes do not offer the gaming side of animation as a full course. Mostly, institutes offer a Flash-based animation gaming. There will be a few schools that will keep coming up and there are quite a few that are already running which will give you the opportunity of a one year course in getting into gaming as a programmer. I already have seen one school in Hyderabad that teaches programming very well - the Indian School of Gaming. Arena also does, but it's more towards the multimedia side. But more will come. Another thing about gaming that I have noticed is that while there are adequate game developers, they haven't done enough in project management. In all our partnerships, we endeavour that the company will also be learning. I feel there is a lot that can be done in taking it beyond this. We have had some preliminary talks with Aptech, on taking it to the next level, with some sort of partnership. ■

(For more of this interview, head over to www.thinkdigit.com)

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